of twenty-four Buddhas; many stories about him exist in Buddhist chronicles which resonate with leitmotifs from the Buddha's life—such as his early years being spent in palaces, the practising of austerities at the end of which the daughter of a Brahman gave him milk-rice, and his having attained enlightenment under a tree (an Udumbara tree).[18] The point is that by the third century BCE a cult around the previous Buddhas was geographically anchored, the Mauryan emperor's beneficence and building activity adding to their importance. The Nigali Sagar edifice that Ashoka enlarged can no longer be traced on the ground. However, for many centuries after his time, a stupa did grace the place associated with Konakamana and, as recorded in Chinese pilgrim accounts, long continued.[19]

The enlargement of the stupa of Konakamana is mentioned by Ashoka six years after he had it done, which is when he visited Nigali Sagar. The pilgrimage is datable to the twentieth year of his reign. By this time there was already in the Nepal terai a kind of pilgrim circuit around places associated with the Buddha. This expanded into the Gangetic plains and is possible to recognize from the emperor's edifices along the path of his pilgrimage. In that crucial twentieth year he paid obeisance at three sacred sites: Nigali Sagar, Gotihawa, and Lumbini, all fairly close to each other. The first two were native places connected with Buddhas who, within the cosmogony, antedated Gautama Buddha. Nigali Sagar was connected to Konakamana, Gotihawa to his immediate predecessor Krakuchhanda, the twenty-second Buddha. Lumbini of course was reputed to be the garden where Maya had given birth to Siddhartha.

How did Ashoka get to these places? The entourage would have traversed the stretch from Pataliputra across the Ganga through north Bihar to the terai. This was then, as it is today, a 'sweep of rich agricultural plains': the archaeological sites there show it clearly.[20] The arterial alignment that linked Pataliputra with the area where Lumbini stood was